



RCCG OCEANIA

Trials & Suffering

PERSEVERE WITHOUT LOOKING BACK

AT A GLANCE

BIG IDEA

Trials are not meaningless interruptions; they are a pathway God uses to produce maturity. Scripture warns against starting the journey and then turning back with divided focus. As God established His promise to Abram, believers are invited to keep their eyes forward and persevere until God's work is complete.

PRIMARY PASSAGES

James 1:2-4

Luke 9:62

Genesis 15:19

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Trials can produce perseverance when faced with faith (James 1:2-4).
- Perseverance is meant to complete its work, leading toward maturity and wholeness (James 1:2-4).
- Following Jesus requires forward-focused commitment rather than looking back (Luke 9:62).
- God's promises establish a long view that strengthens endurance during hardship (Genesis 15:19).
- Spiritual progress is threatened by divided attention; perseverance and focus belong together (Luke 9:62; James 1:2-4).

INTRODUCTION

Perseverance is not simply surviving difficulty; it is continuing with steady faith until God's purpose is formed in the middle of pressure. Scripture reframes trials as a proving ground where endurance is produced, then warns that progress can be undermined by a heart that keeps turning backward. This study connects perseverance with focus: moving forward in obedience, strengthened by the long-range certainty of God's promises.

SCRIPTURE READING

- **James 1:2-4** — James addresses believers facing various trials. He teaches that testing can produce perseverance, and he calls believers to let perseverance complete its work so they become mature, complete, and lacking nothing.
- **Luke 9:62** — Jesus uses the image of plowing to describe discipleship. Looking back while moving forward signals divided focus and an unfit posture for the kingdom of God.
- **Genesis 15:19** — This verse appears within God's covenant promise to Abram about the land. The naming of peoples highlights that God's plan is established beyond immediate circumstances, pointing to a larger timeline and purpose.

KEY POINTS

1. **COUNT TRIALS WITH A NEW PERSPECTIVE** — James calls believers to a surprising posture: to “count” trials with a faith-shaped perspective. This is not pretending pain is pleasant or ignoring grief; it is choosing to view hardship through what God can produce through it. Trials test faith, and that testing can result in perseverance. The point is not that every circumstance is good in itself, but that God can work in the refining pressure so that endurance grows where it otherwise would not. This perspective shift changes how trials are approached. Instead of only asking, “How can this end quickly?” faith also asks, “How can I remain faithful while God forms perseverance in me?”
 - Name a current trial and write one sentence describing how God could use it to strengthen perseverance rather than only disrupt comfort.
 - Practice honest prayer that acknowledges the hardship while choosing faith-filled perspective (without denial or exaggeration).
 - When facing pressure, pause before reacting and ask, “What response would strengthen endurance rather than weaken it?”
 - Identify one habit that helps you keep faith active during testing (such as gratitude, confession, or seeking wise counsel) and commit to it consistently.

Scripture: James 1:2-4

KEY POINTS (CONT.)

2. LET PERSEVERANCE FINISH ITS WORK — James does not only emphasize starting with faith; he emphasizes continuing until perseverance completes what it is meant to do. Perseverance is a process that must be allowed to mature rather than cut short. The passage ties endurance to spiritual maturity: becoming “perfect and complete, lacking nothing.” This describes wholeness—an increasingly steady faith that is not easily fractured by pressure, delay, or disappointment. Letting perseverance finish its work may involve staying faithful in ordinary obedience when results are not immediate. It includes remaining consistent when emotions fluctuate and when outcomes are unclear. Perseverance is not passive resignation; it is active, ongoing trust expressed through continued obedience. The goal is formation, not merely relief.

- Identify one area where you tend to quit early (a responsibility, a spiritual discipline, reconciliation, or obedience) and choose a next faithful step.
- Set a simple perseverance plan for a season of testing: one daily practice that keeps your trust steady (prayer, Scripture reading, or serving).
- Replace “I can’t do this anymore” language with “I will take the next faithful step” language when pressure rises.
- Ask for accountability from a trusted believer to help you continue until perseverance has time to do its work.

Scripture: James 1:2-4

KEY POINTS (CONT.)

3. **COMMIT FORWARD: DON'T LOOK BACK** — Jesus' image of plowing is direct: forward progress requires forward focus. A person who keeps looking back while moving forward cannot keep a straight path; divided attention disrupts the work. In discipleship, looking back can describe a heart that wants to follow Jesus while still clinging to a former identity, former securities, or unfinished loyalties. The problem is not memory; it is divided commitment. The warning is serious: readiness for the kingdom of God is incompatible with a half-turned posture. Perseverance and focus belong together; endurance weakens when attention keeps drifting to what is behind. Forward commitment is not perfection; it is direction. It is choosing the path of obedience without negotiating an escape route.

- Identify one "looking back" pull (a habit, fear, comfort, or distraction) that regularly divides your focus, and name one boundary to limit it.
- Make one concrete decision that aligns your schedule and priorities with following Jesus rather than maintaining divided loyalties.
- When tempted to retreat, speak a simple commitment statement: "I will keep moving forward in obedience."
- Evaluate a current choice by asking, "Does this strengthen my forward focus or train me to keep looking back?"

Scripture: Luke 9:62

KEY POINTS (CONT.)

4. ANCHOR ENDURANCE IN GOD'S PROMISE — Genesis records God establishing covenant promises to Abram, and Genesis 15:19 sits within that covenant context. The naming of peoples emphasizes that God's plan is concrete and defined—not vague, not improvised, and not limited to Abram's immediate situation. This long view matters in seasons of trial. Perseverance grows when faith remembers that God's purposes extend beyond what can be seen quickly. Endurance is strengthened by the certainty that God is faithful to what He establishes. Anchoring in God's promise does not remove hardship, but it steadies the heart. It helps believers resist panic, resist shortcuts, and resist turning back when the present feels unresolved. The covenant context invites trust: God's work often unfolds over time, and perseverance is sustained by remembering that God's promise is larger than the moment.

- When outcomes are unclear, practice reaffirming trust in God's established purpose rather than demanding immediate resolution.
- Write a brief "long-view" prayer that aligns your heart with God's faithfulness and timing.
- In a difficult decision, refuse shortcuts that compromise obedience; choose the path that best reflects trust in God's promises.
- Share with a group member one area where you need long-view endurance, and ask them to pray for steady faith.

Scripture: [Genesis 15:19](#)

GROUP DISCUSSION

Tip: Use these questions to guide the group from seeing → understanding → applying.

OBSERVATION

- In James 1:2-4, what sequence is described from trials to the final outcome?
- What does James command believers to do with perseverance, and what result is promised?
- In Luke 9:62, what work image does Jesus use, and what action is criticized?
- What does "looking back" imply in the picture Jesus gives, based on the task being performed?
- In Genesis 15:19, what does the verse contribute to the covenant context (even if it is brief and specific)?

INTERPRETATION

- Why might James command a deliberate mindset ("count it...") rather than merely describing feelings about trials?
- How can perseverance be "unfinished," and what might it look like to interrupt its work too early?
- What kinds of divided focus can make a person spiritually "look back" while attempting to move forward?
- How does the covenant context in Genesis help frame a longer view of God's purposes beyond immediate circumstances?
- How do James 1:2-4 and Luke 9:62 reinforce each other regarding endurance and focus?

APPLICATION

- What current trial most tempts you to lose perspective, and what would it look like to "count" it with faith this week (James 1:2-4)?
- Where are you most tempted to quit early, and what is one next faithful step that would let perseverance continue its work?
- What is one concrete way you can reduce "looking back" distractions and strengthen forward commitment (Luke 9:62)?
- When you feel discouraged by slow progress, what reminder could help you anchor in God's long-range faithfulness (Genesis 15:19)?
- What habit or practice will you adopt to keep perseverance and focus connected over time?

PRAYER FOCUS

- Ask God for faith to see trials through His purpose and not lose heart under pressure.
- Pray for perseverance to finish its work, producing maturity and wholeness in character.
- Confess divided loyalties and ask for an undistracted, forward-focused commitment to obey Jesus.
- Ask God to anchor your endurance in His unchanging promises when outcomes are delayed or unclear.

NEXT STEP

Identify one current trial and one “looking back” distraction, then take a concrete step of obedience that keeps you moving forward in faith.

CONCLUSION

Perseverance grows when trials are met with faith, endurance is allowed to mature, and discipleship remains forward-focused. Looking back divides attention and weakens readiness, but God’s established promises provide a long view that steadies the heart. The call is to keep moving forward—letting perseverance finish its work until maturity and wholeness are formed.